

Lokesh is unrecognised no more.

"The NCAA level is nothing short of the Olympic level. You are competing with Olympic champions, World Record holders, National Record holders of different countries, world medallists. To win gold at this level is special. After the competition, I've done multiple interviews, but even regular people want to speak to me. Wherever you walk, people know who you are. They compliment and congratulate you. There are people who follow you on social media. People are watching my jumps. They just want to start a conversation. It's completely different from the day before your race to the day after," he says.

Every conversation goes the same way. "People want to know where I'm from. They want to know how it feels to be an NCAA champion. They want to know how I motivate and hype myself and how I go for bigger jumps," he says.

Motivation, Lokesh says, is easy. He thinks about the hard work his parents put in to start his journey in collegiate sport in the USA. He can't help but think about how close a freak injury, a couple of years ago, came to ending that journey, and how hard he had to work just to get another chance to compete at this level. "When I'm jumping, I always think of where I came from. Before every competition, I look back at the challenges I've faced in my life and think about how lucky I am to get an opportunity to show my talent once again," he says.

### **Journey begins**

The idea of competing in the collegiate system first came to Lokesh about eight years ago. Back in 2018, he was considered one of India's most promising junior long jumpers, with a personal best of 7.74m that had won him gold at the Junior South Asian Championships in Colombo, Sri Lanka. After competing at the U-20 World Championships in Tampere, Finland, he attracted the attention of several coaches scouting for track and field programmes in the USA.

Born and raised in Bangalore in a sports-mad family — his father John played football for the Bangalore Police while his sister Monica was a national-level 400-metre runner — Lokesh wasn't certain whether he wanted to leave familiar surroundings. Any plans to shift base were further pushed back after he suffered a serious road accident while travelling to a training session.

**Special company:** Lokesh's 8.21m jump made him only the fourth Indian to win gold at the NCAA Championships. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The physical and mental toll caused him to pull out of the qualifiers for the 2019 World Championships in Doha. "I would have panic attacks. I would stay by myself in a room, and eventually, my friends didn't know what to do. I couldn't even sleep. It was just me and my parents at that time. I had a lot of mental health issues that I was dealing with. I was on a lot of anxiety medication as a result," he recalls.

After he recovered, others nudged him to consider college offers from the USA once again. He was still uncertain. "At that time, I felt if I did go, I'd just be seen as an average athlete who hadn't accomplished anything. I didn't think I was good enough," he says.

As time passed, Lokesh's enthusiasm to train abroad waned, even as he continued to improve. He won gold at the South Asian Games in Kathmandu and recorded a personal best of 7.93m at the selection trials for the World University Games in early 2021.

It was only rekindled in the most painful of circumstances during the second wave of the COVID-19 pandemic in India. When Lokesh's mother fell ill, the family didn't worry at first — until her condition deteriorated suddenly. With doctors preparing the family for the inevitable, Lokesh was permitted to visit her.

"When she was in the last stages of her life, she held my hand, kissed it, and started crying. She just said I had to make the most of whatever opportunity I had. That was the last thing she spoke to me," he says.

Until then, Mary had never tried to influence her son in any way. "In my entire athletic career, she had been nothing but supportive. She was my biggest motivation. If I had a bad day or if I lost, she would tell me she was there for me, and then she would cook my favourite food so that I would feel better. When I lost her, it was as if I lost everything," he says.

The shock sent him into a cycle of despair once again. "I was unable to come out of my room. I wasn't meeting any of my friends. I was once again taking medication for my mental health issues," he says.

But a conversation with his father changed things. "He told me how, without any warning, my mom was no longer with me. You never know when we won't have time to fulfil our desires. Whatever time and opportunity we get,